

Photodynamic Therapy

80.2 Links in PDF documents are not guaranteed to work. To follow a web link, please use the MCD Website.

Tracking Information

Publication Number

100-3

Manual Section Number

80.2

Manual Section Title

Photodynamic Therapy

Version Number

3

Effective Date of this Version

04/03/2013

Implementation Date

07/16/2013

Description Information

Benefit Category

Physicians' Services

Please Note: This may not be an exhaustive list of all applicable Medicare benefit categories for this item or service.

Item/Service Description

Photodynamic therapy is a medical procedure which involves the infusion of a photosensitive (light- activated) drug with a very specific absorption peak. This drug is chemically designed to have a unique affinity for the diseased tissue intended for treatment. Once introduced to the body, the drug accumulates and is retained in diseased tissue to a greater degree than in normal tissue. Infusion is followed by the targeted irradiation of this tissue with a non-thermal laser, calibrated to emit light at a wavelength that corresponds to the drug's absorption peak. The drug then becomes active and locally treats the diseased tissue.

Indications and Limitations of Coverage

Ocular photodynamic therapy (OPT)

Ocular Photodynamic Therapy (OPT) is used in the treatment of ophthalmologic diseases. OPT is only covered when used in conjunction with verteporfin (see section 80.3, "Photosensitive Drugs").

- Classic Subfoveal Choroidal Neovascular (CNV) Lesions - OPT is covered with a diagnosis of neovascular age-related macular degeneration (AMD) with predominately classic subfoveal choroidal neovascular (CNV) lesions (where the area of classic CNV occupies $\geq 50\%$ of the area of the entire lesion) at the initial visit as determined by a fluorescein angiogram (FA). Subsequent follow-up visits will require either an optical coherence tomography or an FA to assess treatment response. There are no requirements regarding visual acuity, lesion size, and number of re-treatments.
- Occult Subfoveal CNV Lesions - OPT is non-covered for patients with a diagnosis of AMD with occult and no classic CNV lesions.

Other Conditions - Use of OPT with verteporfin for other types of AMD (e.g., patients with minimally classic CNV lesions, atrophic, or dry AMD) is non-covered. OPT with verteporfin for other ocular indications such as pathologic myopia or presumed ocular histoplasmosis syndrome, is eligible for coverage through individual Medicare Administrative Contractor discretion.

Cross Reference

Also see NCD on Verteporfin §80.3 [↗](#).

Transmittal Information

Transmittal Number

155

Coverage Transmittal Link

<https://www.cms.gov/Regulations-and-Guidance/Guidance/Transmittals/Downloads/R155NCD.pdf> [↗](#)

Revision History

03/2025 - The purpose of this Change Request (CR) is to provide a quarterly maintenance update of ICD-10 coding conversions and other coding updates specific to National Coverage Determinations (NCDs). No policy is being changed as a result of these updates. ([TN 13097](#) [↗](#)) (CR13939)

10/2024 - The purpose of the Change Request (CR) is to provide a quarterly maintenance update of ICD-10 coding conversions and other coding updates specific to National Coverage Determinations (NCDs). No policy is being changed as a result of these updates. ([TN 12903](#) [↗](#)) (CR13818)

01/2018 - This Change Request (CR) constitutes a maintenance update of International Code of Diseases, Tenth Revision (ICD-10) conversions and other coding updates specific to National Coverage Determinations (NCDs). These NCD coding changes are the result of newly available codes, coding revisions to NCDs released separately, or coding feedback received.

Previous NCD coding changes appear in ICD-10 quarterly updates that can be found at: <https://www.cms.gov/Medicare/Coverage/CoverageGenInfo/ICD10.html>, along with other CRs implementing new policy NCDs. Edits to ICD-10 and other coding updates specific to NCDs will be included in subsequent quarterly releases and individual CRs as appropriate. No policy-related changes are included with the ICD-10 quarterly updates. Any policy-related changes to NCDs continue to be implemented via the current, long-standing NCD process. (TN 2005) (CR10318)

11/2017 - This Change Request (CR) constitutes a maintenance update of International Code of Diseases, Tenth Revision (ICD-10) conversions and other coding updates specific to National Coverage Determinations (NCDs). These NCD coding changes are the result of newly available codes, coding revisions to NCDs released separately, or coding feedback received. (TN 1975) (CR10318)

05/2017 - This change request (CR) constitutes a maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions and other coding updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). These NCD coding changes are the result of newly available codes, coding revisions to NCDs released separately, or coding feedback received.

Previous NCD coding changes appear in ICD-10 quarterly updates that can be found at: <https://www.cms.gov/Medicare/Coverage/CoverageGenInfo/ICD10.html>, along with other CRs implementing new policy NCDs. Edits to ICD-10 and other coding updates specific to NCDs will be included in subsequent, quarterly releases and individual CRs as appropriate. No policy-related changes are included with the ICD-10 quarterly updates. Any policy-related changes to NCDs continue to be implemented via the current, long-standing NCD process. (TN 1854) (CR10086)

02/2017 - This change request (CR) is the 10th maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions and other coding updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). These NCD coding changes are the result of newly available codes, coding revisions to NCDs released separately, or coding feedback received.

Previous NCD coding changes appear in ICD-10 quarterly updates as follows: CR7818, CR8109, CR8197, CR8691, CR9087, CR9252, CR9540, CR9631, and CR9751, as well as in CRs implementing new policy NCDs. Edits to ICD-10 and other coding updates specific to NCDs will be included in subsequent, quarterly releases and individual CRs as appropriate. No policy-related changes are included with the ICD-10 quarterly updates. Any policy-related changes to NCDs continue to be implemented via the current, long-standing NCD process. (TN 1792) (CR9861)

12/2015 - This change request (CR) is the 3rd maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions/updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). The majority of the NCDs included are a result of feedback received from previous ICD-10 NCD CR7818, CR8109, CR8197, CR8691, & CR9087. Some are the result of revisions required to other NCD-related CRs released separately that included ICD-10 coding. Implementation date: 01/04/2016 Effective date: 10/1/2015. (TN 1580) (CR9252)

08/2015 - This change request (CR) is the 3rd maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions/updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). The majority of the NCDs included are a result of feedback received from previous ICD-10 NCD CR7818,

CR8109, CR8197, CR8691, & CR9087. Some are the result of revisions required to other NCD-related CRs released separately that included ICD-10 coding.

These updates do not expand, restrict, or alter existing coverage policy. Implementation date: 01/04/2016 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1537](#)) (CR 9252)

05/2014 - CMS translated the information for this policy from ICD-9-CM/PCS to ICD-10-CM/PCS according to HIPAA standard medical data code set requirements and updated any necessary and related coding infrastructure. These updates do not expand, restrict, or alter existing coverage policy. Implementation date: 10/06/2014 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1388](#)) ([TN 1388](#)) (CR 8691)

09/2012 - CMS translated the information for this policy from ICD-9-CM/PCS to ICD-10-CM/PCS according to HIPAA standard medical data code set requirements and updated any necessary and related coding infrastructure. These updates do not expand, restrict, or alter existing coverage policy. Implementation date: 01/07/2013 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1122](#)) ([TN 1122](#)) (CR 7818)

06/2013 - Effective for claims with dates of service on and after April 3, 2013, CMS expanded coverage of ocular photodynamic therapy (OPT) with verteporfin for "wet" age-related macular degeneration (AMD) in NCD 80.3.1, Verteporfin. CMS revised the requirements for testing to permit either optical coherence tomography (OCT) or fluorescein angiography (FA) to assess treatment response. Corresponding changes are referenced in NCDs 80.2 - Photodynamic Therapy, 80.2.1 - Ocular Photodynamic Therapy (OPT), and 80.3 - Photosensitive Drugs. Effective date: 04/03/2013 and implementation date: 07/16/2013. ([TN 155](#)) (CR 8292)

4/2004 - Covered for 1) subfoveal occult with no classic CNV associated with AMD; and 2) subfoveal minimally classic CNV (where area of classic CNV occupies <50% of area of entire lesion) associated with AMD, provided certain criteria are met. Effective and implementation dates 04/01/2004. ([TN 9](#)) (CR 3191)

8/2002 - Remained noncovered for patients with occult and no classic lesions. Effective and implementation dates 08/20/2002. ([TN 157](#)) (CR 2335)

2/2001 - Covered when used in conjunction with verteporfin for patients with neovascular age-related macular degeneration with predominately classic subfoveal choroidal neovascular lesions (where the area of classic CNV occupies ≥50% of the area of the entire lesion), as determined by a fluorescein angiogram. Effective and implementation dates 07/01/2001. ([TN 135](#)) (CR 1549)

National Coverage Analyses (NCAs)

This NCD has been or is currently being reviewed under the National Coverage Determination process. The following are existing associations with NCAs, from the National Coverage Analyses database.

- [Original Consideration for Ocular Photodynamic Therapy with Verteporfin for Macular Degeneration \(CAG-00066N\)](#)
- [First reconsideration for Ocular Photodynamic Therapy with Verteporfin for Macular Degeneration \(CAG-00066R\)](#)
- [Second reconsideration for Ocular Photodynamic Therapy with Verteporfin for Macular Degeneration \(CAG-00066R2\)](#)
- [Third reconsideration for Ocular Photodynamic Therapy with Verteporfin for Macular Degeneration \(CAG-00066R3\)](#)
- [Fourth reconsideration for Ocular Photodynamic Therapy \(OPT\) with Verteporfin for Macular Degeneration \(CAG-00066R4\)](#)

Additional Information

Other Versions

Title	Version	Effective Between	
Photodynamic Therapy	3	04/03/2013 - N/A	You are here
Photodynamic Therapy (OPT)	2	04/01/2004 - 04/03/2013	View
Photodynamic Therapy	1	08/20/2002 - 04/01/2004	View